

Sweet Sting

There is a buzz among Lucknow farmers as they pursue an alternative source of income despite odds



MANEESH AGNIHOTRY/www.indiatodayimages.com

VERMA SHOWS OFF HIS BEEHIVE

By Subhash Mishra

Brijesh Kumar Verma, a 30-year-old farmer in Gosaiganj on the outskirts of Lucknow, leaves his house on a foggy morning to check out and clean his apiary. An hour later, he is delighted to see bees swarming the mustard field to extract nectar from flowers and come back to the apiaries. Verma is not the only one active in bee-keeping as the Gosaiganj block, now called the 'honey block', has seen hundreds of rural youth keeping themselves busy in honey production. "Lucknow has emerged as the top producer of honey in the entire state," says Dev Narain Patel, a farmer credited with introducing bee-keeping in the area.

Gosaiganj farmers have taken up bee-keeping as a novel source of earning. The youth have been immensely benefited as they have little else to do in the absence of business opportunities and due to lack of electricity in the village. The farmers have also developed related skills like making wooden boxes from local trees. "We buy the queen bees and worker bees from fellow farmers and if the weather is normal and blooms

are available, one can extract honey every ninth day," says Verma. Winter is the peak period for honey extraction as mustard flowers are in full bloom which attract bees spontaneously.

Despite its popularity, producing honey remains an uphill task. As Ajai Singh of Baghauli village says, "It is difficult to get loans or insure apiaries against damage." Moreover, due to lack of flowers after the harvest of mustard, bee-keepers migrate with their apiaries to as far as Bihar. Superstition too creates obstacles as villagers say that if bees take out pollen from the flowers, their plants would not bear fruits, which is refuted by the Executive Director of the National Bee Keeping Board B. L. Saraswat, who says: "Bees are better pollinators than other sources of pollination." He adds that crops pollinated by bees increase yields by up to five times.

Gosaiganj farmers have done their calculations properly. For, India's 8.04 gm per capita per year consumption of honey is far behind the developed countries' 2.5 kg. After all, bee-keeping here is about money. ■